



Physicists help microbiologists

Particle physicists with experience in crowdsourcing are tackling the pandemic. <https://dgit.in/jun20-86>



Niantic to crowdsource data

Niantic plans to use Pokemon Go players to create rich 3D maps of locations around the world. <https://dgit.in/jun20-87>

CROWNING GLORY!

Humanity's biggest and most impressive achievements in the modern age

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ith so much focus on the negative all the time, it's no wonder that people think that their lives are getting

worse, when in fact the opposite is true, based on as many objective metrics as one would like to measure. Whether you look at life expectancy, poverty, economic growth, standard of living... on average, the world is getting better.

At Digit, we're mostly interested in the technology aspect of it all, and honestly don't have too much time to dwell on the distant past. Thus, this feature story. We wanted to look at some of the biggest achievements of humanity in the past three decades or so – in the age of technology, the age of the Internet.

Obviously, the Internet itself is the biggest achievement of mankind in modern times, because it powered almost all of the great innovations that we are going to list in this article. Without the Internet and networking, or modern silicon chip-based technology, the world we live in would look a lot like a classic Hollywood movie, at best!

So, let's explore and find our way to the biggest achievements of modern times, in no particular order.

WIKIPEDIA

Although we did say "no particular order", if we did decide to order this list by importance, Wikipedia would still be very close to the top because of how much more accessible it has made information for the masses. In fact, if

anything, Wikipedia has been given a bad rap by all of the college professors we hear about, who constantly warn students about using information from Wikipedia without fact checking it.

In actuality, Wikipedia is a pretty good resource for novices on a subject that's more core science based. For example, if you have absolutely no idea about intermediate physics topics such as string theory or Einstein's theories of Relativity, you could go to college and pay huge amounts to get a Bachelor's or Master's degree in physics and acquire an intermediate level understanding of the topic. But how many of us can afford that? More importantly, how many of us without science degrees also would like to get more than the layman's understanding of the topics? That's the sweet spot for Wikipedia.

It's no small feat that hundreds of thousands of people took it upon themselves to impart knowledge, even if very occasionally that knowledge is limited or wrong. And what did they do it for? Absolutely nothing at all. None of us care who these people are, or what they do, because Wikipedia doesn't make a fuss about who contributed what – unless you click edit and go see the edit history of a page, which 99.99% of people don't do. Even then, all you see is a bunch of weird usernames. However, several people contribute to popular pages, and several more edit those pages and make comments, and there is a rudimentary system of peer review instituted there. And all of this is given to the general public for completely free! There's a reason why many of us writers donate money to Wikipedia, and that is because we know how hard it is to find free time to do such voluntary work. If you can afford it, and if

you find yourself looking up a couple of dozen Wikipedia pages a week for information, we urge you to donate to them as well. Wikipedia might actually be the largest social achievement in modern history!

WEB BROWSER

We can't remember how many times we were told that browsers were dead. Over a decade ago when Web 2.0 was a buzzword, and even later when smartphones and apps seemed headed on the path of being all pervasive, there were those who insisted the days of the web browser were numbered. Then, in the past few years, we started talking about progressive web apps, and again the browser is hot... but think about it. If you have been using technology for 10 or 20 years, was there ever a point in your life where you felt you could do without a web browser?

For many people the web browser is the internet!

Although apps connect using the same Internet pipes, and display content in pretty much the same way, except they do it inside a different wrapper...

many don't think of that experience as "the internet". Inside the app is Facebook, WhatsApp, Twitter, etc., but inside the browser

is the internet! The great unknown; uncharted space. A land of possibilities where what one finds depends largely on one's mood and what they're searching for. You could jump from browsing Wikipedia to banking, or reading about a film to checking the latest news. Sure, there are apps for almost all of these activities, but they limit you in some way or the other, and try and wall you off. The browser is all encompassing.

The first browser was released on Christmas Day 1990, by Sir Tim



Sir Tim Berners-Lee,
the Father of the WWW